Tenant Repair Helper

From a photo to the legal clock in five minutes.

Day 0

dated letter to the landlord

Same day

city complaint, pre-filled

No account

any language, on your phone

BRICK CITY BUILDS 2026 · NEWARK, NJ · OCT 14

THE PROBLEM

A maze between you and the fix.

Broker. Manager. Owner LLC. Sub-manager. A language barrier. And a rule nobody told you about.

01

WHO IS RESPONSIBLE?

02

WHAT DOES THE LAW WANT FIRST?

03

WHERE DO I FILE?

04

WHAT HAPPENS ON DAY 8?

THE HIDDEN RULE

Written notice first. Every day lost.

NJ law: tell the landlord in writing before anything else counts. Only 911 comes before the letter.

01

ANTI-REPRISAL PROTECTION

needs the letter

02

REPAIR-AND-DEDUCT

needs the letter

03

RENT WITHHOLDING

needs the letter

04

CONSTRUCTIVE EVICTION

needs the letter

WHAT WE BUILT

Photo in. Letter, city step, clock out.

A mobile web wizard. One question per screen. No account. Rules in plain code decide the steps; AI only reads the photo.

01

PICK + PHOTO

AI checks the photo matches the category and pre-fills the answers.

02

WHO'S RESPONSIBLE

Parcel owner of record + the city's Non-Compliant Landlord List.

03

DATED LETTER

Print, PDF, email, or copy. Certified mail recommended.

04

CITY STEP + CLOCK

Pre-filled complaint, call script. Day 0 today, next step Day X.

WHY THE ORDER MATTERS

Each step feeds the next.

01	**THE LETTER**	Starts the legal clock. Protects against retaliation.
02	**CITY COMPLAINT**	The only way an inspection becomes a Notice of Violation.
03	**VIOLATIONS**	Count toward the city's public Non-Compliant Landlord List.
04	**COUNCIL + PRESS**	What actually moved the city in every case we found.

THE NUMBERS

169 heat complaints. 4 landlords. 12 months.

City of Newark Non-Compliant Landlord List, first edition, April 2026.

44
Colonnade Apartments
heat / hot water, 12 mo

72
Boomers Investment Group
heat / hot water, 12 mo

34
FHTDD, LP
heat / hot water, 12 mo

19
Hudson Valley Property Group
heat / hot water, 12 mo

Source: newarknj.gov/666 · data/noncompliant-list.json

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Violations are not repairs.

Eight Newark cases, 2015 to 2026. Same pattern every time: complaint, violation, nothing, press, action.

2017

NO-HEAT CASE

Five days without heat. City complaint went nowhere. A TV call brought code enforcement the same day.

2020–26

ELEVEN80

Five years from first complaint to lawsuit. One documented mold finding produced one rent abatement.

2026

VILLA VICTORIA

Years of complaints, multiple city violations, no repairs as of March. Named on the list in April.

DEMO

Maria, 123 Example St. No heat since Monday.

The one path we demo, start to finish.

01
PICK "HEAT"

02
PHOTO CHECK
"Looks like heat. We filled in what we could."

03
ADDRESS
Owner of record + list check

04
PLAN
Day 0 letter · same-day hotline 973-733-6471 · portal

05
LETTER
Print · email · copy

06
"I SENT IT"
Clock starts. Day 0.

Made-up tenant and address. No real personal information.

Day 0. Same day. Day 7. Then help.

DAY 0	**TELL THE LANDLORD**	Dated letter, certified mail + email, photos attached. Evidence log starts.
SAME DAY	**TELL THE CITY**	Heat, hot water, water, no lock: hotline + portal, DCA BHI if 3+ units.
DAY 7–14	**IF NOTHING HAPPENS**	Ward council member email, Rent Control petition, press-ready packet.
THEN	**FREE LEGAL HELP**	LSNJ 1-888-576-5529 · OTLS 973-877-9424. Never withhold rent without them.

Not legal advice. The app explains public rules and points to free legal help.

WHAT'S NEXT

Two sides, then the whole ward.

Today: the tenant side. Next: the landlord, then the data the city says it doesn't have.

01

LANDLORD INBOX

One queue for repair requests. Optional, but valuable if they join.

02

SHARED REPAIR THREAD

Tenant, landlord, repair person. Auto-translated.

03

WARD DASHBOARDS

Complaints by ward and by landlord, to the council member as data.

04

FOLLOW-UP ENGINE

Not fixed by Day X? Draft the next escalation automatically.

THE TEAM

Built today by [names].

ROLE

[Name]

[What they built today. One line of background.]

ROLE

[Name]

[What they built today. One line of background.]

ROLE

[Name]

[What they built today. One line of background.]

THE ASK

Help us put this in a tenant's hand.

01	**A HOUSING ORG**	Pilot with ten real Newark tenants this winter.
02	**CODE ENFORCEMENT**	Ten minutes to confirm the portal categories and the hotline flow.
03	**LEGAL AID**	Review the letter and every one-line "why".
04	**TRANSLATORS**	Spanish and Portuguese first.